David Geisert

Game & UX Designer · Prototyping AI-native play

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Game designer and prototyper with 14 years turning new technology into play: **100+ games shipped** and **$100M+ in revenue** from games I worked on, F2P systems at Zynga and Rocket Games, a $1M+ launch title on Oculus Quest, and five years prototyping AI and AR experiences at Meta Reality Labs. I build playable proofs-of-concept in hours, test them with players, and tune AI behaviour until it feels good to play. I set UX and product direction for cross-functional teams, turn research into design principles, and build shared frameworks that other teams adopt. I also founded and run **Jamference**, a fortnightly AI game jam.

RECOGNITION

- ★ **Digital Champion of the Year 2026**, Camden Digital Inclusion (AI talks for the community)
- ★ **4th place**, Cursor 2.5-hour Hackathon, London 2025 (*Cursor Party*)
- ★ **Double winner**, ML & AI and Innovative Entertainment, Creating Reality 2018 (*Flicksync*)
- ★ **Primary inventor** on 2 US patents (US 20230259194, US 20240194040)
- ★ **Winner, Multimodal AI**, AI Tinkerers Demopalooza at MongoDB.local London, 2025 (5-min live music-video speed run)
- ★ **Most Fun entry**, Jamference #1, 2026 (*Kitty Kingdom*)
- ★ **7th place**, Hugging Face Open Source AI Game Jam 2023 (*Hexagon Tactics*)
- ★ **Multiple company awards** at Meta for executive GenAI demos on Orion AR glasses

EXPERIENCE

Story Machine AI · Founder & CEO

Jun 2025 – Present

- **Jamference:** Founded and facilitate a free, week-long AI game jam on itch.io every two weeks, prompting creators to find new uses for AI across genres. I design each brief (a theme plus a mandatory restriction, e.g. "No Text" or "Movement Input Only") and the rating rubric (Fun, AI Use, Polish, Theme), run the community, and ship an entry myself each round.
- **The Play Machine:** Designed an AI game-creation tool that turns plain-language prompts into playable browser games with generated code, art and audio. Shipped jam games with it (*Trojan General*, *Machine Colony*, *Locked in the Pyramid*).
- **Interactive generative stream:** Built a live AI video stream where audience comments changed the story on screen within about 6 seconds. I used it to define design principles for agency and latency: how much control viewers need, and how quickly they need to see it, inside a generative system.
- **Story Machine platform:** Set the product and UX strategy and owned the architecture of an AI filmmaking pipeline (story → reusable character assets → shots → edit). MVP in about a month; hired and led 2 engineers and a marketer. Pivoted from Unity to React/Supabase for faster iteration.
- **AI feature film:** Directed a fully AI-generated feature film in 5 weeks on a $2,500 generation budget, sponsored by BytePlus/ByteDance.
- **Another Like That:** Designed a recommendation product for London events, built on vector similarity. Went from concept to live in 3 weeks.

Meta Reality Labs · Product Design Prototyper (IC6)

Jul 2020 – May 2025

- **Object locking for Meta Connect:** Led prototyping (team of 6, 3 months) for AR glasses that recognise real objects, pin stable 3D markers to them and pass them to an LLM (e.g. a recipe from what's on the counter). I designed the feedback states (animation, status cues, TTS) so cloud latency felt like the system "thinking" rather than lag, and specified them for engineering.
- **Orion AR messaging:** Spent 2 years building Unity prototypes on-device and running user studies on cognitive load while walking, notification frequency and social comfort. I explored AI summarisation and activity-aware interruptions, and turned the findings into interaction principles that shaped the final messaging design.
- **Exec demos:** Built GenAI demos on Orion that communicated the product vision to the Board and partner executives, winning multiple company awards.
- **AI prototyping platform:** Pitched, built consensus for and launched a shared prototyping framework of 20+ AI services and hundreds of models. Teams on 80+ projects adopted it to go from idea to working prototype in an hour.
- **Mixed reality and colocation:** Lead designer and prototyper on room reconstruction for Quest, the first time users could add objects to the play area. Designed safety systems to protect users sharing a space in colocated headsets, and published colocation samples for external developers.

- **Community and craft:** Ran the London Reality Labs demo fairs and grew them into Meta's 2nd-most-attended. Rebuilt Unity developer onboarding as a structured course for new prototypers. Rated as exceeding expectations every cycle.

Coinflip Studios · Co-Founder, Lead Designer & Developer — Jun 2018 – Jul 2020

- **Ninja Legends:** Led design and development of a fast melee VR game. I spotted that existing titles wouldn't port to standalone headsets and steered the team to build for that hardware. It became one of the first post-launch Oculus Quest titles, made over $1M, and shipped on Quest, Rift, Steam and PSVR.
- **Guessy Sketch: Telephone Pictures:** Game designer, PM and front-end developer on a social drawing game for Messenger Instant Games; a team of 4 shipped it in 5 weeks.

Rocket Tiger Studios · Founder — Jun 2017 – Jun 2018

- **Flicksync (my first AI-in-VR project):** Recreated the Alice in Wonderland tea party scene. The player speaks a character's lines, speech recognition scores the performance, and the AI cast react and carry the scene on. Won 2 categories at Creating Reality (USC), and I recently revived it with playable mobile and VR builds.
- **Comets Wake (SteamVR):** Procedural mesh and level generation for unlimited unique levels and objects.

Rocket Games · Lead Systems Designer — Feb 2015 – Jun 2017

- **Systems design:** Led a cross-functional team to design a competitive tournament system and measured its impact against KPIs: retention up 5%, monetisation up 10%.
- **Portfolio:** Product-managed 16 mobile games in 2 years, each earning over £1,000/day. Built live-ops messaging (1M+/day) and ran $50k+/day of profitable user acquisition, which helped grow revenue 2.5x.

Cat Duo · Co-Founder — Jul 2013 – Sep 2015

- Funded a board-game companion app on Kickstarter with award-winning designer James Ernest. Invented a cross-platform real-time local multiplayer system that enabled new in-person mobile game mechanics.

Zynga · Product Manager — Mar 2012 – Jun 2013

- Led small teams shipping features on tight schedules for the Flash and Unity *Storyville* games, and streamlined internal tools to cut development time.

INDEPENDENT GAMES & JAMS · more at dgeisert.itch.io

- **Cursor Party** (2025): Built in 2.5 hours at Cursor's London hackathon by directing AI coding (4th place). Instead of drawing the art, I had the AI build a sprite editor, then use it to make the sprites.
- **Starry Meows** (2026): Made for Jamference #3, whose restriction was "No Text", so every cue had to come through visuals and play. The world is drawn from thousands of moving brush strokes in the style of *Starry Night*.
- **Kitty Kingdom** (2026): Began as my Jamference #1 entry (voted Most Fun); I kept iterating after the jam, growing it into a deck-building roguelite.
- **Hexagon Tactics** (2023): Hugging Face Open Source AI Game Jam entry (7th), with units, names and art generated in real time.
- **Severed Heads, United Hearts** (2023): An experiment in making LLM agents the core mechanic: persuade AI courtiers to back you.

SKILLS

Game design	Core loops, systems and balance, progression and roguelite structure, game feel, procedural generation, competitive and social systems, playtesting and iteration
UX	High-fidelity and on-device prototyping, user studies and synthesis, multimodal input (voice, gaze, hands, touch), design principles and frameworks, design specs for engineers, workshop facilitation, responsible design (safety, social comfort, cognitive load), live demos
Product & data	UX and product strategy, KPIs (retention, monetisation), live ops, user acquisition, stakeholder alignment, storytelling for executives
AI for play	LLM agents and behaviour tuning, speech recognition and TTS, image, video, music and SFX generation, segmentation, 3D generation and gaussian splats
Engines & tools	Unity (C#), Godot, browser/WebGL, Quest, Rift, PSVR, SteamVR, iOS, Android, Blender, Cursor, Claude Code, AI Studio, React, Supabase, ComfyUI

EDUCATION & COMMUNITY

M.S. Environmental Engineering, Stanford University

B.S. Polymer Fiber Engineering, Georgia Tech

Admissions judge and mentor, StartX (Stanford accelerator), 2021–present

Writer, OnceUponAnAlgorithm.org; 2 AI-illustrated books (2023)